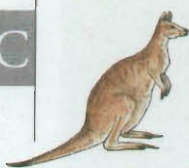


COOK, JAMES



UNTIL THE MID-18TH CENTURY, European explorers were motivated by trade or plunder. James Cook, a British naval captain, began a new form of exploration – he was more interested in scientific research. From 1768 to 1779, he made three voyages to the South Pacific, applying scientific methods to navigation for the first time, and making astronomical observations that would help future sailors. He also carefully recorded everything he saw, bringing back many specimens and drawings of previously unknown flora and fauna.



Early life

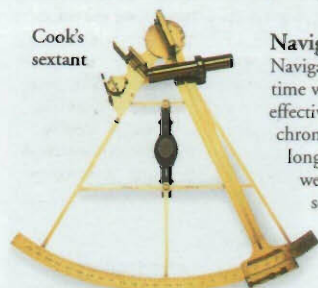
James Cook was born in the town of Marton-in-Cleveland near Whitby, England in 1728. He went to sea as a boy, sailing in the Baltic before joining the British Royal Navy in 1755. Cook rose quickly through the ranks and was given command of his first ship in 1759, during the Seven Years' War with France.

Port of Whitby, England



The Endeavour

During the 1760s, Cook mastered the skills of navigation. These were put to good use when he was asked in 1768 to sail to Tahiti in the South Seas to observe the transit of the planet Venus across the sky. His choice of ship was unusual: the *Endeavour*, a converted collier familiar to Cook, and known for its toughness and ability to carry a heavy cargo.



Cook's sextant

Navigation

Navigation during Cook's time was primitive but effective. Cook used a chronometer to determine longitude (position east-west) and a quadrant or sextant to determine latitude (position north-south).

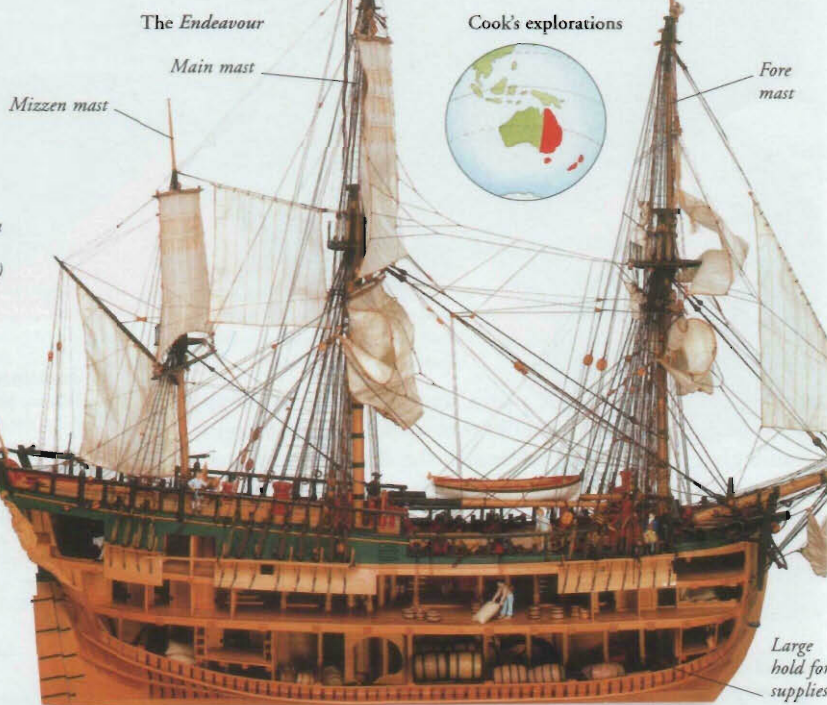


Lemons and limes

Diet

Cook was the first sea captain to take measures against scurvy – a disease caused by lack of vitamins – and supplied his crew with fresh fruit, meat, and vegetables wherever possible.

Red ensign
(British
naval flag)



The Endeavour

Main mast

Mizzen mast

Cook's explorations



Fore mast

Large hold for supplies

Mapping the Pacific

Cook made three voyages around the Pacific, circumnavigating New Zealand, mapping the east coast of Australia, and exploring many islands. He guessed correctly that there was an area of frozen land around the South Pole, and confirmed that Australia was a large island and not part of any southern continent.

Joseph Banks

Cook took with him botanist Joseph Banks, artist Sydney Parkinson, and a team of scientists. They discovered many species, such as the breadfruit and the kangaroo, previously unknown to Europeans. One area yielded so many new species that they called it Botany Bay. It is now a suburb of Sydney, Australia.



Joseph Banks



Some of
Parkinson's
illustrations

Death of Cook

On his third voyage, which started in 1776, Cook came across the Hawaiian Islands, which he named the Sandwich Islands. He spent the winter of 1778–79 in Hawaii, learning much about the inhabitants, and he returned in the spring of 1779, after exploring the west coast of America. This time, however, the local people were less friendly, and after a quarrel broke out, Cook was stabbed to death.



Cook is killed fighting the Hawaiian islanders.



Hawaiian clubs, used against Cook

JAMES COOK

1728 Born in Marton-in-Cleveland, Yorkshire, England

1755 Joins Royal Navy

1759 Takes command of his first ship

1768–71 Sails to the Pacific Ocean to observe the transit of Venus; explores Tahiti, New Zealand, and Australia

1772–75 Second voyage: maps many of the Pacific islands and sails south towards Antarctica

1776–79 Third voyage: sails into North Pacific; looks for inlet into Arctic Ocean

1779 Stabbed to death in Hawaii

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